



Bouncing back: James Rodriguez inspired Colombia's return to the World Cup, leading the side to a 3-0 victory over Bolivia that secured qualification for the 2026 finals with a match to spare. AP

to share centre-forward duties with Goncalo Ramos. The latter's role has diminished since Martinez's appointment in 2023, leaving the 226-cap veteran as Portugal's preferred option up front.

The Selecao das Quinas have been drawn in Group K alongside Colombia, DR Congo and Uzbekistan. While progression to the knockout rounds is expected, the early knockout stages have proved Portugal's Achilles heel in recent tournaments. That is where the side will hope its talisman can once again show the way.

After missing out on the tournament four years ago, Colombia secured qualification by finishing third in CONMEBOL qualifying. Nestor Lorenzo, who was part of the coaching staff during the country's quarterfinal run in 2014, will seek to recapture some of the feel-good factor from that campaign. It is no surprise, then, that James Rodriguez has been brought back into the fold.

Rodriguez will spearhead a gifted squad packed with players who have accumulated extensive experience at some of Europe's biggest clubs. La Tricolor are the favourites to finish second in the group and may need some magic from the left foot of the 2014 World Cup Golden Boot winner to go deeper into the tournament.

DR Congo ended its painstaking 52-year wait for a World Cup appearance when Axel

ON THE RADAR



Bruno Fernandes (Portugal)

Manchester United's midfield maestro has been at his creative best this year, breaking the Premier League record for most assists in a single season. If those around him convert the chances he creates, Portugal will have every chance of making a deep run.



Luis Diaz (Colombia)

Leaving the reigning Premier League champion for the Bundesliga appeared a risky move at the start of the 2025-26 season. But 49 goal contributions and three trophies later, he has cemented his status as one of Europe's finest wingers and will be eager to showcase his quality on the World Cup stage.